the next six months, 1,500 people were sentenced to prison terms on trumped-up charges, two were executed.

In a moment of high drama, Karl Schirdewan – a dour figure with tinted glasses and a baldpate – sent out a memo to all SED district offices on 21 June to deploy members to discover the true attitude of workers: ‘This evening they must go to the bars, and, so to speak, listen in on the conversations.’9 When completed, Schirdewan’s probe noted countless thousands of FDJ members had taken part in the protests. This was enough to make Honecker’s restless mind wander off as he sensed plots and resentments everywhere.

The Russians also fed his insecurities after complaining that the FDJ education programme ‘only existed on paper’. Albert Norden, a member of the Central Committee, later rounded on him. He carped that his administrative talents were uneven, and he shouldn’t confront young people as a politician. ‘He should be their friend and fool about with them for a bit. His speeches shouldn’t consist of great political theorems.’10 For all these reasons, Otto Grotewohl feared that the party was losing its grip on young minds, and complained he had ‘not observed the slightest tendency towards development’ in Honecker’s work in recent years.11 Fred Stamp, a personal assistant to Grotewohl, even recommended Honecker be replaced by a ‘more capable, more experienced comrade’.12

As ever, Honecker tried to bear tribulation stoically by flitting around the Berlin region in the wake of 17 June. With the fiery zeal of a preacher, he sold a new gospel of openness to the workforce, assuring the SED would solve existing problems and improve living conditions. ‘During the two preceding days,’ he explained, ‘I had talked to workers in all departments of the VEB Engine Works factory in Babelsberg. Thus, I got to know their thoughts, ideas and desires and could explore the causes of their discontent.’13 Displaying more personality and less authority, he admitted 17 June showed some FDJ members had not recognised the nature of the ‘fascist provocation’ and were, therefore, not in a position to counter ‘enemy propaganda’ with effective arguments. He added: ‘This is to be attributed to a lack of political knowledge and the lack of well-organised youth-orientated political training within the organisation.’